CS5290 Memory-Centric Computer Architecture · Course Project Plan (Revision 2, 23 October 2026)

Reliable and Secure ReRAM Crossbar Accelerators for Deep Neural Networks

Noise-, Fault- and Attack-Aware Hybrid SLC/MLC In-Memory Computing

Abstract. Resistive RAM (ReRAM) crossbars perform matrix–vector multiplication in place, removing the weight movement that dominates the energy of deep neural network (DNN) inference. Their practical use is limited by device non-idealities (conductance variation, stuck-at faults, limited multi-level precision, ADC quantisation and IR drop) and by the exposure of in-memory weights to fault-injection attacks. Building on HyFlexPIM, which places important weights in reliable single-level cells (SLC) and the remainder in dense multi-level cells (MLC), we will (i) develop and verify a bit-accurate crossbar simulator, (ii) reproduce the key published baselines, (iii) characterise the impact of each non-ideality, (iv) recover accuracy through noise-aware training, noise-aware mapping and fault-aware mapping, and (v) propose a *unified rank-to-slot mapping* that jointly accounts for cell tier, stuck-at faults and IR drop at zero runtime hardware cost. We further evaluate a multi-level-cell bit-flip attack and an analog checksum defence, and quantify all overheads with NeuroSim. Work proceeds in two phases: **Phase 1** takes two Transformers (DistilBERT and BERT-Base on SST-2) through every step; **Phase 2** extends the same pipeline to CNNs, to a second GLUE task (MRPC) and to an FPGA emulator on the AMD Kria KV260.

Changes from Revision 1. (a) Work is split into two phases, Transformers first (Section 5); (b) DistilBERT is added as a fast development model; (c) public SST-2 fine-tuned checkpoints replace training from scratch, and the INT8 reference is post-training quantisation; (d) all compute runs on **Kaggle** GPU notebooks; (e) simulator details now match the implementation (7 SLC / 4 MLC cells per 8-bit weight); (f) a progress-to-date section is added.

1 Papers Included in the Project

The project is anchored on one primary paper, extends four foundational works, and draws on a small set of recent papers for baselines and techniques (Table 1).

Table 1: Papers included in the project and their role.

Role	Paper	What we use
Primary	HyFlexPIM, Song *et al.*, ISCA 2025	Hybrid SLC/MLC analog PIM; SVD-based gradient redistribution; importance-based tier mapping. Reproduced and extended.
Foundational	ISAAC, Shafiee *et al.*, ISCA 2016	Reference crossbar organisation (tiles, bit-slicing, ADC sharing); PPA baseline.
architecture	PRIME, Chi *et al.*, ISCA 2016	ReRAM main-memory PIM organisation; signed-weight mapping.
Reliability	Xia *et al.*, DAC 2017	Fault-tolerant training and remapping for stuck-at faults; baseline for our mapping.
Security	Rakin *et al.*, ICCV 2019	Bit-Flip Attack (progressive bit search); reproduced on crossbar-stored weights.
Supporting	Rasch *et al.*, Nat. Commun. 2023	Hardware-aware (noise-aware) training baseline.
	Chen *et al.*, DATE 2017	Optimal (bipartite) fault-aware weight mapping baseline.
	FREEMAP, ISLPED 2026	Zero-overhead folding of permutations into adjacent layers.
	SWIM, DAC 2022	Hessian-based weight-importance metric.
	Liu *et al.*, ITC 2018; RADAR, DATE 2021	Checksum-based error and attack detection.
	Luo *et al.*, TCAD 2020	FPGA emulation of ReRAM crossbars with noise.

2 Project Overview

Problem. A ReRAM crossbar stores weights as conductances G_{ij}; applying input voltages V_i to the rows yields column currents $I_j = \sum_i V_i G_{ij}$, i.e. an analog dot product. Real devices deviate from their programmed values, some cells are permanently stuck, multi-level cells have narrow noise margins, and wire resistance

attenuates currents. Because weights reside in memory, an adversary able to perturb a few cells can also collapse model accuracy.

Gap in the primary paper. HyFlexPIM models device noise only as i.i.d. multiplicative Gaussian weight noise; it does not consider stuck-at faults, IR drop or drift, applies no noise-aware training, ignores *which physical cells* hold a given weight, provides no security analysis, and is evaluated on Transformers only.

Objectives.

O1 Build a bit-accurate, verified ReRAM crossbar simulator and reproduce published baselines.

O2 Characterise the accuracy impact of each non-ideality, individually and combined.

O3 Recover accuracy via noise-aware training, noise-aware mapping and fault-aware mapping.

O4 Secure crossbar-stored weights against bit-flip attacks at low overhead.

O5 Quantify the energy, latency and area cost of every technique; demonstrate an FPGA emulator (Phase 2).

Planned contributions.

C1 *Unified rank-to-slot mapping.* A single optimal assignment that places each SVD component in a physical crossbar slot, jointly considering cell tier (SLC/MLC), stuck-at faults and IR-drop position, with no runtime permutation hardware.

C2 *Tier-aware noise-aware training.* Fine-tuning with SLC-level noise on protected components and MLC-level noise elsewhere, to reduce the required SLC fraction.

C3 *Multi-level-cell bit-flip threat model.* Attack cost measured in conductance-level shifts rather than bit flips, and the effect of level encoding (binary vs. Gray).

C4 *Analog checksum defence.* A per-crossbar checksum column evaluated against benign noise (false alarms) and an adaptive, checksum-aware attacker.

Scope. One simulator serves all models.

- **Phase 1 – Transformer track (current):** DistilBERT (36 encoder linear layers) and BERT-Base (72 layers) on GLUE SST-2, for direct comparison with HyFlexPIM. DistilBERT is the fast development model; BERT-Base is the reported result.
- **Phase 2 – Extension:** BERT-Base on GLUE MRPC; a CNN track (ResNet-20, ResNet-18, VGG-16 on CIFAR-10); KV260 FPGA emulation with ResNet-20.

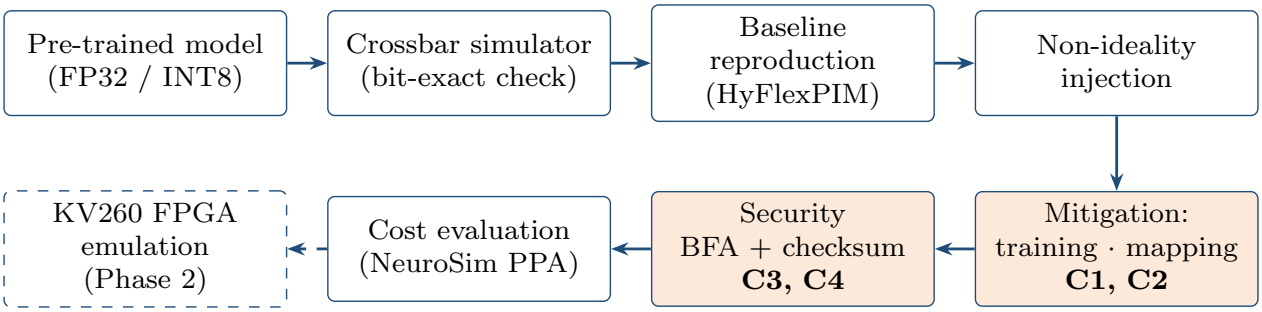


Figure 1: Project workflow. Shaded stages contain our contributions; dashed stage is Phase 2.

3 Methodology

3.1 Step 1 – Baseline Models and Quantisation

Phase 1. We use public checkpoints already fine-tuned on SST-2 from Hugging Face, so no training from scratch is needed:

- DistilBERT: `distilbert-base-uncased-finetuned-sst-2-english`
- BERT-Base: `textattack/bert-base-uncased-SST-2`

We report two references on the 872-sentence SST-2 validation set: (i) *FP32 accuracy* of the unmodified model, and (ii) *INT8 accuracy*: weights quantised with symmetric per-output-channel 8-bit scales and activations with an 8-bit per-tensor scale (post-training quantisation, no noise, no SVD). These are the accuracy references for all later steps.

Phase 2. FP32 baselines for ResNet-20, ResNet-18 and VGG-16 on CIFAR-10 are trained on Kaggle, followed by INT8 quantisation-aware training; BERT-Base on MRPC uses a public fine-tuned checkpoint.

3.2 Step 2 – Bit-Accurate Crossbar Simulator

We implement a PyTorch library (`reram_sim`) in which every target linear layer (and, in Phase 2, every convolution via im2col) is replaced by a crossbar layer that models the analog computation explicitly:

- **Quantisation and signed weights.** Each weight row is quantised to a signed 8-bit integer $q \in [-127, 127]$ and stored as a differential pair, $q = q^+ - q^-$, $w_{ij} \propto G^+_{ij} - G^-_{ij}$.
- **Bit-slicing.** The 7-bit magnitude is split into base-2^b digits, $q^{\pm} = \sum_s 2^{sb}\, d^{(s)}$, with $b = 1$ (SLC, 7 cells) or $b = 2$ (MLC, 4 cells), tiled into 128×128 arrays.
- **Conductance levels.** Digit d is programmed as $G = G_{\min} + d\,\Delta$, $\Delta = (G_{\max} - G_{\min})/(2^b - 1)$, with $G_{\max} = 1$ (normalised) and $G_{\max}/G_{\min} = 100$. MLC levels are therefore $3\times$ closer than SLC levels.
- **Inputs, ADC and shift-and-add.** Inputs are quantised to 8 bits by the DAC; each slice and 128-row tile is read by an ADC and combined digitally:

$$y_j = \sum_t \sum_s 2^{\,t+sb}\, \mathrm{ADC}\Big(\sum_i x_i^{(t)} w_{ij}^{(s)} \Big), \tag{1}$$

  where $x_i^{(t)}$ is the t-th input bit. The current implementation applies whole 8-bit inputs and a batch-calibrated ADC; bit-serial inputs and a fixed (offline-calibrated) ADC range are added in this step.
- **Chips.** One seeded random generator programs a whole model; each seed is one simulated chip.

Verification. With all non-idealities disabled and a lossless ADC of $b_{\mathrm{ADC}} = \lceil \log_2(R(2^b - 1) + 1) \rceil$ bits (R rows), the simulator must reproduce the INT8 model exactly on every layer and in end-to-end accuracy. Automated tests (16 so far: toy matrices, a toy MLP, a Transformer encoder layer and DistilBERT end-to-end) are re-run after every change.

3.3 Step 3 – Reproduction of Baselines

- **HyFlexPIM method.** Our re-implementation: every encoder linear layer is factorised as $W \approx U_k \Sigma_k V_k^\top$ with the parameter-preserving rank $k = \lfloor mn/(m+n) \rfloor$ (e.g. $k = 384$ for 768×768), fine-tuned on SST-2 (8 epochs, AdamW, lr 2×10^{-5}) to recover truncation loss, and scored by $I_r = |\partial L / \partial \sigma_r|$ over 2048 calibration sentences. The top 20% of components per layer are placed in SLC, the rest in MLC; on hardware each tier is two crossbars back to back,

$$y = U_{\mathrm{SLC}}(\Sigma V^\top)_{\mathrm{SLC}}\, x + U_{\mathrm{MLC}}(\Sigma V^\top)_{\mathrm{MLC}}\, x + b.$$

- **HyFlexPIM results.** Accuracy versus noise for five placement policies (all-SLC, all-MLC, gradient, magnitude, random) and accuracy versus SLC fraction (0–100%). Expected: gradient placement stays close to all-SLC at 20% SLC. Results are cross-checked against the authors' open-source code.
- **ISAAC/PRIME-style PPA.** NeuroSim V1.5 energy, latency, area, TOPS/W and ADC energy share, against a digital baseline (Step 6).
- **Bit-Flip Attack.** The attack of Rakin *et al.* reproduced on the 8-bit weights of BERT-Base and DistilBERT, recording flips needed to reach random-guess accuracy (50%) (Step 7).
- **Phase 2.** HyFlexPIM on CNNs: whether importance concentrates in few components, as it does for Transformers.

3.4 Step 4 – Non-Ideality Modelling and Characterisation

Each effect is an independent, seeded module (Table 2). Parameters are taken from measured ReRAM data in the literature and the noise models of IBM AIHWKIT; the simulator is cross-checked against AIHWKIT and, for IR drop, Sandia CrossSim. Initial sweeps use 5 chips per point; final results use at least 20 chips, reporting mean, 5th-percentile and worst-case accuracy, together with a per-layer sensitivity analysis.

Table 2: Modelled non-idealities.

Effect	Model	Sweep	Status
Programming variation	$\tilde{G} = G + \sigma G_{\max}\mathcal{N}(0,1)$, fixed per chip; same σ hurts MLC more	$\sigma \in [0, 10]\%$	Implemented
Read noise	Fresh Gaussian perturbation at every inference	0.5–2%	To add
Stuck-at faults (uniform)	Cell forced to $G_{\max}$ or $G_{\min}$ with probability p	0.1–20% of cells	Implemented
Stuck-at faults (clustered)	Whole rows / columns dead	0.1–5% of lines	To add
Limited levels	1 or 2 bits/cell; smaller level margin for MLC	SLC vs. MLC	Implemented
ADC resolution	Clamp and round of column partial sums per tile	3–8 bits	Implemented
IR drop	Position-dependent attenuation along word/bit lines	$r_{\text{wire}}\times$ size (64–256)	To add
Drift (optional)	Time-dependent conductance relaxation	1 s to 1 week	Optional

3.5 Step 5 – Accuracy Recovery

5a. Noise-aware training (NAT). We train $\min_\theta \mathbb{E}_\eta\big[L(f(x;\theta\odot(1+\eta)))\big]$, resampling noise every mini-batch with straight-through quantisation. Methods are evaluated incrementally: (i) Gaussian noise injection; (ii) the hardware-aware training recipe of Rasch *et al.* via AIHWKIT; (iii) stuck-at fault injection during training; (iv) worst-case-oriented objectives.

5b. SVD and noise-aware mapping. Starting from the Step 3 tiering, we compare gradient, magnitude, Hessian (SWIM) and Fisher importance at the component and layer level, and select per-layer SLC fractions under a NeuroSim area/energy budget.

Contribution C2 – Tier-aware noise-aware training

During the HyFlexPIM fine-tune, components currently assigned to SLC receive SLC-level noise and the remaining components MLC-level noise, $\eta_r \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2_{\tau(r)})$, with the assignment τ refreshed periodically. The network learns to concentrate information where it is protected. *Hypothesis:* equal accuracy at a lower SLC fraction.

5c. Fault-aware mapping. Given a chip's stuck-at fault map, logical rows are assigned to physical rows by solving the linear assignment problem

$$\pi^\star = \arg\min_\pi \sum_i C_{i,\pi(i)}, \qquad C_{ij} = \sum_k I_{ik}\big(w_{ik} - \hat{w}^{(j)}_{ik}\big)^2, \tag{2}$$

where $\hat{w}^{(j)}_{ik}$ is the value realised when row i is stored on physical row j. It is solved optimally with the Hungarian algorithm (`scipy.optimize.linear_sum_assignment`); row and column permutations are alternated. Output-column permutations are folded into the next layer's input order (as in FREEMAP), so no permutation hardware is required. Spare rows, allocated by importance, handle clustered faults. Baselines: no mitigation, Xia *et al.*, Chen *et al.* and fault-injection training.

Contribution C1 – Unified rank-to-slot mapping

In an SVD-factorised layer $W = U(\Sigma V^\top)$ the k components form an internal dimension that can be permuted (columns of U and rows of $\Sigma V^\top$ together) without changing the layer output. Each physical slot s is characterised by its tier $\tau(s) \in \{\text{SLC}, \text{MLC}\}$, its fault pattern F_s and its IR-drop attenuation α_s. We solve

$$\min_\pi \sum_r I_r\, \mathbb{E}\big[\|\Delta_r(\pi(r))\|^2 \,\big|\, \tau, F, \alpha\big] \quad \text{s.t. SLC capacity budget,}$$

unifying tier allocation (HyFlexPIM), fault-aware remapping and IR-drop-aware placement in a single optimal assignment with zero runtime hardware overhead. An ablation isolates each cost term.

5d. Complementary techniques (time permitting). Drift compensation, sign-flip weight storage matched to fault patterns, activation clipping, and reduced ADC precision for MLC arrays.

3.6 Step 6 – Hardware Cost Evaluation

All configurations are evaluated in NeuroSim V1.5 (Transformers; Phase 1) and DNN+NeuroSim V1.4 (CNNs; Phase 2) for energy per inference, latency, area, TOPS/W and TOPS/mm^2, with an energy breakdown (ADC, array, peripherals, buffers). The overhead of each technique (additional SLC cells, spare rows, checksum

columns) is reported. The central result is the *accuracy–efficiency Pareto front* obtained by varying the SLC fraction.

3.7 Step 7 – Security

Threat model. The adversary shifts cell conductance levels through physical disturbance (thermal crosstalk, write or read disturbance), restricted to cells physically reachable from the attacker's access pattern.

Contributions C3 and C4 – MLC-aware attack and analog checksum defence

C3. The Bit-Flip Attack is reformulated with cost measured in conductance-level shifts: in a 2-bit cell one shift may flip two bits. We test whether MLC lowers attack cost and whether Gray-coded levels remove this advantage.

C4. Each crossbar holds a checksum column $G_{i,\text{chk}} = \sum_j G_{ij}$; tampering is flagged when $\left|\sum_j I_j - I_{\text{chk}}\right| > \theta$, with θ set from the benign-noise distribution (cost $\approx 1/128$ columns). Unlike prior checksum schemes for random faults (X-ABFT) or digital weights (RADAR), we evaluate against an adaptive attacker that preserves the checksum, countered by a secret-weighted checksum.

Evaluation: flips or level shifts required to reach random-guess accuracy, with and without each defence (noise-aware training, SLC protection, Gray coding, checksum); detection ROC and AUC; detection latency; recovery by row reprogramming.

3.8 Step 8 – FPGA Emulation on AMD Kria KV260 (Phase 2)

The emulator implements the arithmetic of the simulator exactly, so that the simulator serves as its golden model. BERT-Base does not fit on-chip, so the emulator targets ResNet-20 (0.27 M weights).

- **Processing system (ARM, PYNQ):** loads conductance codes and stuck-at masks, configures ADC precision and noise level through AXI-Lite, and streams activations via DMA.
- **Programmable logic (Vitis HLS):** several 128×128 virtual-crossbar tiles, each with on-chip weight storage, parallel MAC lanes, hardware Gaussian noise generators (Tausworthe-based, following Luo *et al.*), ADC rounding, shift-and-add and an optional checksum column.
- **Mapping:** fault-aware and rank permutations are folded into the stored weights and need no logic, demonstrating C1's zero-overhead property.
- **Validation:** bit-exact agreement with noise disabled, statistical agreement with noise enabled, speed-up over the software simulator, resource utilisation, clock frequency and board power.

4 Tools and Frameworks

Table 3: Software and hardware tools.

Purpose	Tool	Role in the project
Core simulation	Custom PyTorch library	Crossbar model, non-idealities, SLC/MLC tiers, mappings; FPGA golden model
Models and data	Hugging Face `transformers`, `datasets`	Pre-trained checkpoints; GLUE SST-2 (and MRPC)
Analog reference	IBM AIHWKIT	Calibrated ReRAM noise models, simulator validation, NAT baseline
IR-drop validation	Sandia CrossSim	Circuit-level parasitic solver
Primary baseline	HyFlexPIM code	Cross-check of our SVD and tiering pipeline
Energy, latency, area	NeuroSim V1.5 / DNN+NeuroSim V1.4	PPA of all configurations
Optimisation	SciPy, PuLP / OR-Tools	Hungarian assignment and ILP
Security	Public BFA implementation	Attack reproduction and extension
FPGA (Phase 2)	Vitis HLS, Vivado, Kria-PYNQ	KV260 emulator (Linux x86 host required)
Compute	**Kaggle** notebooks (NVIDIA T4 GPU), laptops	All training and Monte Carlo sweeps run as Kaggle notebooks (30 GPU-h/week, 12 h sessions); laptops for development and unit tests only

5 Execution Order and Progress

5.1 Phase 1 – DistilBERT and BERT-Base on SST-2

Tasks run in this order; each uses the output of the previous one.

#	Plan step	Task	Status
1	Step 1	FP32 accuracy of both pre-trained models	**Done**
2	Step 1	INT8 (post-training) accuracy of both models	**Done**
3	Step 3	HyFlexPIM pipeline: SVD, fine-tune, gradient importance, 20% SLC split	**Done**
4	Step 2	Crossbar simulator (quantise, differential pair, bit-slice, noise, faults, DAC/ADC) + 16 tests	**Done**
5	Step 2	End-to-end check: simulator at $\sigma = 0$ matches the SVD model	**Done**
6	Step 3	Five placement policies vs. programming noise ($\sigma = 0$–10%)	**Done**
7	Step 3	Accuracy vs. SLC fraction (0, 5, 10, 20, 30, 50, 100%) for gradient, magnitude, random and Fisher importance (Fisher brought forward from Step 5b), $\sigma = 3, 5, 7.5\%$, 20 chips	**Done**
8	Step 4	Stuck-at fault sweep (0–5% of cells, half stuck at $G_{\max}$, half at $G_{\min}$) for all six placements, 20 chips	**Done**
9	Step 2/4	Add bit-serial inputs, fixed calibrated ADC (then ADC-bits sweep, 3–8 bits), read noise, clustered faults, IR drop	**Done**
10	Step 5a	Noise-aware training	**To do**
11	Step 5b	**C2** tier-aware noise-aware training	**To do**
12	Step 5c	Fault-aware mapping (Hungarian)	**To do**
13	Step 5c	**C1** unified rank-to-slot mapping	**To do**
14	Step 7	Bit-Flip Attack, **C3**, **C4**	**To do**
15	Step 6	NeuroSim V1.5 PPA and accuracy–efficiency Pareto front	**To do**

5.2 Phase 2 – Extension

(16) BERT-Base on MRPC; (17) CNN track: ResNet-20/18 and VGG-16 on CIFAR-10 with QAT, conv layers via im2col, repeat tasks 5–15; (18) KV260 FPGA emulator with ResNet-20.

5.3 Results to Date

Tasks 1–3. Kaggle T4, 8 fine-tuning epochs, 20% SLC per layer. The SLC and MLC parts sum back to the factorised weight with a maximum absolute error below 4×10^{-6}. INT8 is the original (non-SVD) model with its encoder layers quantised to 8 bits.

Model	FP32	INT8	SVD truncated	SVD + fine-tune	Components in SLC
DistilBERT (36 layers)	91.06%	90.37%	89.68%	89.11%	3,324 / 16,584 (20.0%)
BERT-Base (72 layers)	92.43%	91.86%	89.33%	90.14%	6,648 / 33,168 (20.0%)

Tasks 5–6. With no noise ($\sigma = 0$) the BERT-Base crossbar model reaches 89.7–90.3% for every placement, within 0.5 points of the digital SVD model (task 5). Table below: mean SST-2 accuracy of BERT-Base over 5 simulated chips versus programming noise (task 6).

Placement	$\sigma = 0$	2%	3%	5%	7.5%	10%
All SLC	89.9	89.3	89.1	87.8	85.9	79.7
All MLC	90.0	87.3	83.9	66.3	52.2	51.3
Gradient, 20% SLC (HyFlexPIM)	90.3	89.7	89.5	85.8	72.1	60.3
Magnitude, 20% SLC	89.7	89.9	90.0	88.6	83.5	72.0
Random, 20% SLC	90.0	89.9	87.7	78.8	58.8	49.1

All-MLC collapses to near random guessing for $\sigma \geq 5\%$, and protecting 20% of components recovers most of the loss, so the choice of components matters (random is far worse). Unexpectedly, *magnitude* selection outperforms HyFlexPIM's *gradient* selection for $\sigma \geq 5\%$, on DistilBERT as well.

Task 7. Mean SST-2 accuracy of BERT-Base over 20 simulated chips versus the fraction of components stored in SLC (same fine-tuned SVD model; only the SLC/MLC assignment changes). All-MLC (0%) and all-SLC (100%) are shown for reference.

σ	Policy	0%	5%	10%	20%	30%	50%	100%
5%	Gradient	66.8	83.0	82.0	86.5	86.1	88.1	88.0
	Fisher		87.3	87.9	88.1	88.3	88.4	
	Magnitude		88.0	88.6	88.7	88.9	88.9	
	Random		72.5	73.6	76.2	77.8	83.4	
7.5%	Gradient	53.0	66.2	62.9	73.0	73.9	79.6	85.7
	Fisher		75.6	78.9	80.3	82.2	83.8	
	Magnitude		79.4	81.8	84.1	85.5	85.6	
	Random		53.6	54.2	55.2	57.5	67.3	

Findings (DistilBERT shows the same ordering): (a) the ranking is magnitude > Fisher > gradient $\gg$ random at every SLC fraction, and magnitude also has the best worst-chip accuracy; (b) Fisher, which squares per-sentence gradients and so cannot cancel, closes most of the gap between gradient and magnitude, so sign cancellation explains part of the gradient method's weakness but not all of it; (c) with magnitude selection, 5–10% SLC is enough at $\sigma = 5\%$ and 30% at $\sigma = 7.5\%$ to come within 0.5 points of all-SLC, while gradient needs 50%; (d) at $\sigma = 3\%$ every importance-based policy is within 1 point of all-SLC even at 5% SLC.
Open issues. (i) The SVD loss (2.3 points for BERT-Base) will be compared with the accuracy reported by HyFlexPIM, and the fine-tuning schedule revisited if the gap is larger. (ii) For DistilBERT, fine-tuning slightly reduced accuracy, suggesting over-fitting; validation-based early stopping will be added. (iii) Hypothesis for the remaining magnitude–Fisher gap (to be tested): programming noise is a fixed fraction of $G_{\max}$, so the large-σ_r components carry the most absolute error. Magnitude selection is used as the default policy from task 8 onwards, with gradient kept as the HyFlexPIM baseline.